

LAND AT
GREAT HOUSE FARM
LLANDOUGH

PLANNING
APPLICATION
89/01396/OUT



COMMENTS AND RECOMMENDATIONS BY
THE GLAMORGAN-GWENT ARCHAEOLOGICAL TRUST LTD



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1 Introduction

1.1 This report has been divided into sections which outline the archaeological interest of Llandough and the archaeological potential of the development site, the place of archaeological interests in the planning process and a summary of our recommendations. For further information on the archaeology of Llandough members are respectfully referred to Biglis, Caldicot and Llandough (ed D M Robinson) published in the British Archaeological Reports Series, No 188 (1988).

2 Summary of the Archaeological Interest of Llandough and the Archaeological Potential of the Development Site

2.1 The church of St Dochdwy and the surrounding area is of considerable archaeological and historical interest. The churchyard is almost certainly on the site of an early christian monastic foundation which may have been founded as early as 650 AD; the cross shaft near the church dates to the tenth or eleventh century, and is of a scale and style that would mark an important religious site.

2.2 In 1979 during the course of the Wales and West Housing Association Development to the south of the church, emergency archaeological excavation revealed evidence of high quality. In summary part of an Iron Age farmstead was located, together with a Roman villa of high status, a dark age cemetery, a medieval monastic grange belonging to Tewkesbury Abbey, a late medieval village and a post medieval mill and farm. It is important to note that there was no visible trace of the farmstead, villa, cemetery or grange prior to the commencement of development at this site. Although valuable information was recovered during the excavation, the circumstances of discovery were unsatisfactory to both archaeological interests and those of the developer. It would not be in the interests of archaeologists, developers or the local community were such a situation to arise again.

2.3 At present our information on the Great House Farm area is limited to the records of the recently demolished property which was listed as a 'county treasure'. There is a possibility that archaeological deposits relating to earlier activity on this site may survive, and we believe that this possibility should be tested by a suitably qualified archaeologist.* This could be achieved in a rapid cost effective way by the use of a mechanical excavator under archaeological supervision. The results of such an operation would form the basis of an assessment report which would detail the archaeological implications of redevelopment and suggest what, if any, further archaeological action would be desirable. We estimate that the investigation and report could be completed within a period of two weeks at a cost of £2,000.

3 Archaeology and Planning

3.1 There are a number of planning provisions that are relevant to the archaeological interest of this particular site.

* As listed in the Institute of Field Archaeologists Directory of Members 1988-9

3.2 South Glamorgan Structure Plan (June 1989)

Policy EV 15

Sites and Buildings of Archaeological Interest

Sites and buildings of archaeological interest will be protected by management measures and the control of new development, and provision will be made for the recording and rescue of important archaeological features, where they are to be disturbed by new development.

3.3 East Vale Local Plan (February 1987)

Policy E9

Where proposals for development may affect areas of archaeological interest, efforts will be made to secure adequate time and access for survey, excavation and recording.

Parts of the plan area have considerable archaeological interest, and careful study can answer many questions about the area's long history. As new development can destroy valuable evidence, relevant planning proposals will be referred to the Glamorgan-Gwent Archaeological Trust for their observations. If a site is considered to be of archaeological significance efforts will be made to ensure that information is gained from the site before the remains are lost.

(It should be noted that at the consultation stage in the preparation of the East Vale Local Plan the Glamorgan-Gwent Archaeological Trust understood that this site was designated for housing and a recommendation was made that there should be provision for prior archaeological investigation. (Letter to John Maitland Evans 1 October 1982, extract reproduced in Appendix to this Report)).

3.4 Welsh Office Planning Guidance and Statutory Instruments

Circular 61/81

Section 26 states: 'where application is made to the local planning authority for planning permission to carry out development which would affect any monument, whether scheduled or unscheduled, the desirability of preserving the monument and its setting is a material consideration.'

Statutory Instrument 1988, No 1812

Section 4 confirms that a Local Planning Authority is empowered to direct an applicant to provide further information that may be necessary to enable a planning application to be determined.

Circular 1/85

Appendix B, Section 3 states that 'if any part of the development is premature, the proper course is to refuse permission for it.'

As even an unscheduled monument is a 'material consideration' in the planning process we believe that in this particular case the Local Planning Authority has insufficient information to determine the application. We therefore recommend that this application should not be determined until BP Properties have provided an archaeological assessment report prepared by a qualified archaeologist.*

* As listed in the Institute of Field Archaeologists Directory of Members 1988-9

3.5 The British Archaeologists and Developers Liaison Group Code of Practice

The Glamorgan-Gwent Archaeological Trust endorses the voluntary Code of Practice drawn up by the British Property Federation and the Standing Conference of Archaeological Unit Managers. The Code of Practice also receives the support of Government Ministers (eg, Mrs Bottomley, Hansard 24 May 1989, p 602). Negotiations concerning archaeological assessment of this site have been undertaken with BP Properties via their agents Debenham Tewson prior to the current application for planning permission. Our approach was in line with the Code which states that 'archaeologists shall give developers the earliest possible notice of the need for site investigations'. Although the Code stated that 'developers shall allow both adequate time (and financial support) to permit an archaeologically worthwhile investigation' it has not been possible to reach a satisfactory agreement with BP Properties. This we regret, particularly in view of the fact that the Llandough Community Council agreed most generously to contribute £100 towards archaeological costs if the balance of costs was met by BP Properties.

We appreciate that in this case BP Properties are not strictu sensu the developers as they wish to sell on the land with outline planning permission. Nevertheless as the applicants for planning permission we believe, as stated above, that it is their responsibility to provide sufficient information to enable the Local Planning Authority to determine the application. The Code of Practice provides an effective means by which BP Properties could acquire the necessary archaeological information.

4 Summary of Recommendations

4.1 An archaeological assessment of the site should be undertaken and a report, recommending what, if any, further archaeological action is needed, should be compiled. (Section 2.3)

4.2 On the basis of the County Structure and Local Plan policies, Welsh Office planning guidance and Statutory Instrument 1988, No 1812 we recommend that the Local Planning Authority should not determine this application until an archaeological assessment report prepared by a qualified archaeologist* has been provided by BP Properties. (Section 3.4)

4.3 The British Archaeologists and Developers Liaison Group Code of Practice should be used to provide the means by which BP Properties can acquire the necessary archaeological information for the Local Planning Authority to determine the application. (Section 3.5)

Appendix: Extract from letter to J Mairland Evans 1 October 1982 from GGAT

"Ty Mawr Farm (H2.1) is designated as a three-acre residential site. As you will see from the enclosed information the settlement at Llandough developed considerably from farming and fishing (Environmental Matters 7.3). Recent excavations at Llandough by the Trust revealed early occupation, part of the villa and medieval grange buildings. There remains a possibility that occupation continues to the north of the church; provision should be made, therefore, for thorough investigative work prior to the development."

* As listed in the Institute of Field Archaeologists Director of members 1988-9



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Front cover St Dochdwy's church
and the former Ty-Mawr
farm buildings